

MENULENS

Snap a menu. See your meal.

An MVP that turns any restaurant menu photo into visual dish cards — name, price, description, and a real photo of the dish.

- Menu Photo → Dish Cards

THE PROBLEM

Menus describe food. They rarely show it.



Text-only menus

Most menus are just names and prices — no photos to go on.



Unfamiliar dishes

Regional or foreign dish names leave diners guessing what they'll get.



Slow decisions

Diners hesitate, ask the server, or just order the safe thing.

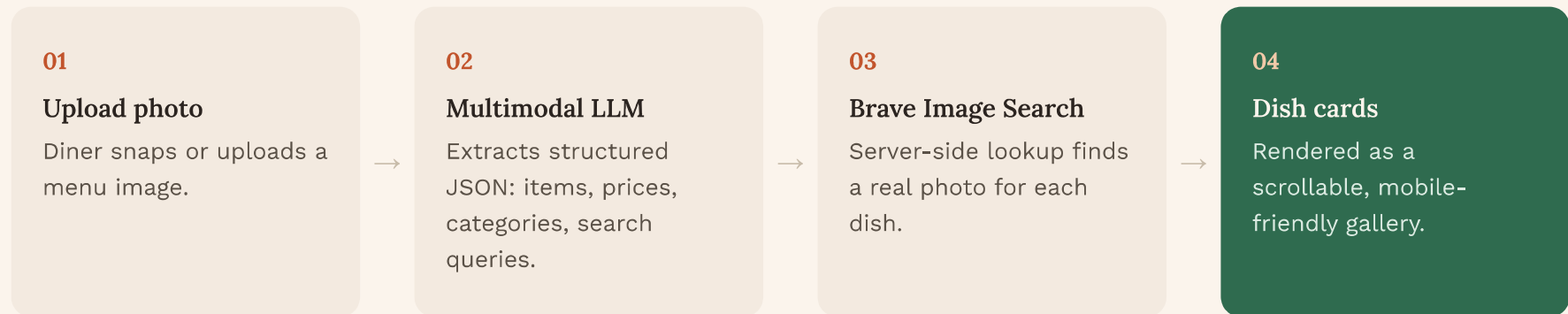
THE IDEA

One photo of the menu becomes a gallery of what you can order.

Upload or snap a picture of any menu. In seconds, get a card for every dish — complete with a real photo, price, and description.

HOW IT WORKS

A four-step pipeline



STEP 02

Every dish becomes structured data

The LLM reads the menu image and returns strict JSON — no invented prices, no invented restaurant names.

- Name, description, category, price
- 3 ranked image-search queries
- Visual keywords for ambiguous dishes
- Confidence score (0–1)

```
{  
  "name": "Chicken Katsu Curry",  
  "category": "Entrees",  
  "price": "$16.95",  
  "confidence": 0.93,  
  "search_queries": [  
    "Chicken Katsu Curry Japanese food",  
    "Chicken Katsu Curry dish",  
    "Chicken Katsu Curry rice"  
  ]  
}
```

STEP 03

First good photo wins — no reranking

Query priority

1. "Restaurant name" + "dish name"
2. "Dish name" + food
3. "Dish name" + cuisine
4. Fall back to visual keywords
if ambiguous

On a hit

Store `image_url`,
`image_source_url`, and
`image_source_name`. Runs
server-side — API key never
reaches the browser.

On a miss

`image_url` is null — the card
shows a graceful placeholder
instead of breaking.

KEPT DELIBERATELY SIMPLE

MVP guardrails

- ✓ Max 25 menu items, 3 queries per item
- ✓ Strict JSON mode + defensive parsing
- ✓ Request timeouts on both API calls
- ✓ Stop at the first usable image — no reranking
- ✓ Brave & LLM keys stay server-side
- ✓ Clear error states: bad image, LLM/Brave failure, no items found

BEYOND THE HACKATHON

Where this could go next

Image reranking

Score candidates for visual match instead of taking the first result.

Caching

Reuse dish images across diners to cut repeat API costs.

Dietary tags

Flag vegetarian, spicy, and allergen info from menu context.

Multi-language menus

Translate and extract from non-English menus.

Never wonder what you ordered again.

Menu Photo → Dish Cards. Built in a weekend, ready to demo.